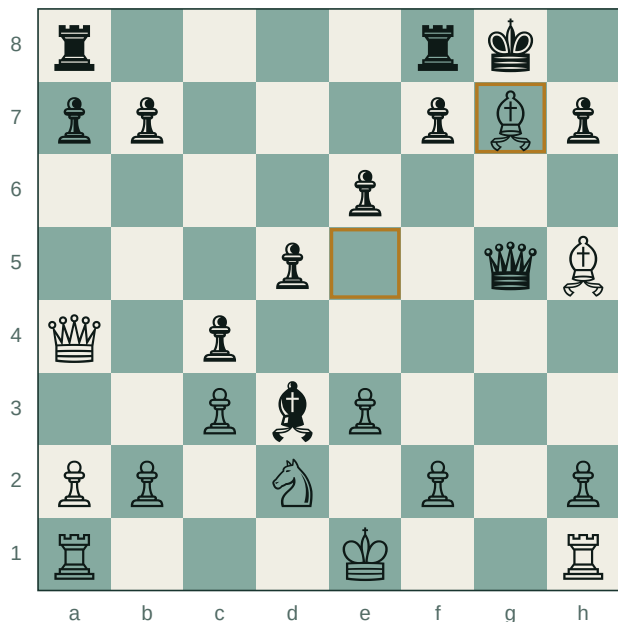


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 15

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 15.Bxg7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

15...Qxh5 16. Qd1 Qxd1+ 17. Rxd1 Kxg7

15...Qxh5 The queen captures the bishop on h5. Recorded reply: **16.Qd1**.

16...Qxd1+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. From d1 it attacks king on e1, rook on a1 and knight on d2. Recorded reply: **17.Rxd1**.

17...Kxg7 The king captures the bishop on g7.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -5 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on e1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on g7 and bishop on h5. Check for tactical protection.